all the rival groups, leaving very little for themselves. The rival groups tried to carve out exclusive zones where only their writ should run, which on occasion would lead to inter-factional clashes or targeted killings of rival leaders. As per the Cease Fire Ground Rules (CFGR), an agreed number of leaders was allowed to travel with their bodyguards, who were permitted to carry weapons. It was a bit of a grey area and our own troops had to operate in this grey zone of uncertainty, a task that I felt was more difficult than CI/CT operations in J & K, where at least troops could open fire. All the groups had a certain number of designated camps in which their cadres had to stay and the AR, or even the local police, were not supposed to enter these camps as per the terms of the CFGR. The largest of these was the NSCN (IM) camp at Hebron near Dimapur, which was like their General HQ. All the top leaders, including Isac and Muihwah, used to reside within the camp.

Another of the NSCN (IM) camps was at Mukalimi in the Zunheboto district, an area dominated by the Sumi tribe, to which Isac belonged. In end-December 2013, a few cadres from this camp misbehaved with some local women, leading to a stand-off between the villagers and the camp. The villagers demanded that the offending cadres be handed over to them to be tried as per Naga customary law. Strictly speaking, this was a local law-and-order issue and the AR should have had nothing to do with it. Nevertheless, we were told to try to secure the area of the camp to prevent any bloodshed. So here we were, protecting a camp of the NSCN (IM), who were technically our adversaries, from the wrath of the very people they claimed to represent. It was a tense two to three days. My class fellows from school had come to spend the New Year with me, but I was glued to the telephone or camping on a hillock from where I had a clear view of the camp as well as the village, ready to

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